

STUFF PRETTY GOOD

The No-Regrets Home Office Guide

*The exact 5-piece setup that matters, at three budgets --
and the traps to skip so you buy once, not twice.*

2026 Edition

The 5 pieces that actually matter

After years of testing setups, everything that affects your comfort and output comes down to five things. In order of impact per dollar:

1. **Chair.** You sit in it 8+ hours. This is where the money goes first. A bad chair costs you a back; a good one disappears under you.
2. **Monitor position.** Not the monitor itself -- its position. Top of the screen at or slightly below eye level, an arm's length away. A \$30 monitor arm beats a \$300 monitor upgrade for neck pain.
3. **Keyboard + mouse.** Your hands touch these all day. You don't need enthusiast gear; you need something that doesn't make your wrists ache by 4pm.
4. **Lighting.** A \$40 desk lamp aimed at the wall behind your monitor kills eye strain more than any "blue light" glasses.
5. **Desk.** Last, because any flat stable surface works. Standing desks are nice; they're not the first upgrade.

Rule of thumb:

Spend in the order above. Most people do it backwards -- fancy desk, cheap chair -- and pay for it in chiropractor bills.

Budget tiers

The Starter -- ~\$300 total

Ergonomic mesh chair (used office liquidators are gold here), your existing table, a monitor arm, a basic wireless keyboard/mouse combo, and a daylight desk lamp. This setup beats 80% of "aesthetic" desks on social media for actual comfort.

The Sweet Spot -- ~\$800 total

Mid-range ergonomic chair with lumbar support, 27" 1440p monitor on an arm, quality keyboard, vertical or trackball mouse if your wrist complains, bias lighting behind the monitor, and a solid (non-wobbling) desk. This is where most people should stop.

The Forever Setup -- ~\$1,500 total

Premium ergonomic chair (the kind with a 10-year warranty), 32"+ or ultrawide monitor, split or tented keyboard, sit-stand desk frame with a top you like, proper task lighting, and cable management that means you never see a wire. Buy once, enjoy for a decade.

The traps: what to skip

Gaming chairs.

Built for looks, not spines. A \$150 "racing style" chair loses to a \$150 used Steelcase/Herman Miller every single time.

Blue-light glasses as a first fix.

Fix your lighting and screen distance first. Glasses are a distant third.

- **Desk toys before ergonomics.** The headphone stand can wait until your neck doesn't hurt.
- **4K for text work.** At 27", 1440p is the sweet spot. 4K matters for video/photo, not spreadsheets.
- **Cheap sit-stand frames.** A wobbly standing desk is worse than a solid sitting one. Either spend enough for stability or skip it.
- **"Ergonomic" everything at once.** Change the chair, live with it two weeks, then decide what's next.

Ergonomics cheat sheet

Body part

Rule

Quick fix

Eyes	Top of screen at/below eye level	Monitor arm or books
Neck	Screen one arm's length away	Push monitor back
Shoulders	Relaxed, elbows ~90 deg	Lower chair / raise desk
Wrists	Straight, not bent up	Lower the keyboard
Back	Lumbar supported, feet flat	Lumbar pillow
Legs	Thighs parallel to floor	Adjust chair height

The 20-8-2 rule:

Every 20 minutes, stand for 8, move for 2. No chair -- however expensive -- replaces movement.

Your buy-once checklist

- Chair with adjustable lumbar and armrests (test-sit if possible)
- Monitor arm (single or dual, rated for your screen weight)
- Keyboard that keeps wrists straight
- Mouse that fits your hand (palm vs. claw grip matters)
- Desk lamp with warm-to-daylight adjustable temperature
- Surge protector (your gear deserves better than a wall socket)
- Cable management: one under-desk tray + velcro ties

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